



SECTION A
Reading Skills

20 marks

1. Read the following passage carefully :

10

- (1) Saffron is a spice that's long been revered across the globe, captivating hearts and palates with its deep-red hue and complex flavour. It is one of the most prized spices that you can find on this planet. Just like gold is among the most valuable metals in the world, saffron means the same in the world of spices. Also known as 'kesar' in Hindi, it has a rich history and is often called an ancient spice. Saffron is being used since ages in various foods made for the royals and the elite as it contains medicinal properties.
- (2) Originating from the delicate stigma of the saffron crocus flower, it transforms the ordinary into the extraordinary, infusing dishes with a subtle, earthy sweetness that adds a special taste to the palate. Saffron has a strong exotic aroma and a unique flavour and is used to colour and flavour many Mediterranean and Asian dishes, particularly rice, fish and English, Scandinavian, and Balkan breads.
- (3) Saffron forms the backbone of several iconic dishes from around the world, such as the Spanish rice, seafood dish Paella, the French stew Bouillabaisse, Italian rice dish Risotto Milanese, the Indian ice cream Kesar Kulfi, Pakistani rice dish Biryani, and baked Iranian rice Tachin. Saffron's rich red colour is attributed to crocin; its bitter taste, to picrocrocin; and its distinctive aroma, to safranal.
- (4) Saffron is cultivated chiefly in Iran but is also grown in Spain, France, Italy, and parts of India. A labour-intensive crop, the three stigmas are handpicked from each flower, spread on trays, and dried over charcoal fires for use as a food flavouring and colouring agent.
- (5) Most historians speculate it was first domesticated in Iran, but south-western Greek islands remain strong contenders. Traders, conquerors, and world explorers introduced it to China, India and the Middle East. From there, it travelled to Mediterranean Europe.



- (6) The high retail value of saffron is maintained in world markets because of labour-intensive harvesting methods, which require some 444,000 hand-picked saffron stigmas per kilogram — equivalently, 150,000 crocus flowers per kilogram. Forty hours of labour are needed to pick 150,000 flowers. Almost all saffron grows in a belt from Spain in the west to India in the east. Iran is responsible for around 88% of global production. Afghanistan comes second, and Spain is the third largest producer, while the United Arab Emirates, Greece, the Indian subcontinent and Morocco are among minor producers.
- (7) Given its high price, adulteration is quite common, unfortunately. Adulterants like beetroot or pomegranate are used to enhance red colour; silk fibres, oil, or wax are used to add bulk, and powdered saffron can be adulterated with turmeric and paprika.

Answer the following questions, based on the above passage :

- (i) What is the tone of the writer in the given lines ? 1
Rationalise your response in about 40 words.
“Saffron is being used since ages in various foods made for the royals and the elite as it contains medicinal properties.”
Paragraph (1)
- (ii) Which of the following statements best describes the comparison made in the sentence ? 1
“Just like gold is among the most valuable metals in the world, saffron means the same in the world of spices.”
(A) Gold and saffron have similar physical properties.
(B) Gold and saffron have equal monetary value.
(C) Saffron is considered the most valuable spice, similar to how gold is valued among metals.
(D) Gold and saffron are both rare commodities in the global market.
Paragraph (1)



- (iii) List any two points why saffron is revered across the globe. 2
Paragraphs (2) and (3)
- (iv) Fill in the blank from the given options : 1
In the phrase 'backbone of several iconic dishes', the word 'iconic' refers to _____.
(A) delicately cooked
(B) widely recognized
(C) peculiar and rare
(D) strange and infamous Paragraph (3)
- (v) Complete the sentence appropriately : 2
Saffron has a labour-intensive cultivation process which involves _____.
Paragraph (4)
- (vi) State whether the following statement is True or False : 1
According to historians, saffron was first used in the kitchens in Iran.
Paragraph (5)
- (vii) Which of the following statements best describes the reason for saffron's high retail value ? 1
(A) Due to its magical or mystical properties.
(B) Because it can only be grown in specific regions.
(C) Due to its labour-intensive cultivation process and its relatively low yield per plant.
(D) Because traders, conquerors, and world explorers hoard it.
Paragraph (6)
- (viii) Support the writer's view with evidence from the text that saffron is often adulterated. 1
Paragraph (7)